THE WESTERN SECTOR

LADAKH

The Western Sector, to a great extent, unlike NEFA was a ‘known’ region, as the fighting in 1947-48 with Pakistani tribal lashkars had extended almost up to the Leh airfield. After Prime Minister Nehru had announced in August 1959 that the army had taken over the NEFA border, there was initially very little movement on the ground, perhaps owing to Thimayya’s reluctance to induct troops into the inhospitable Himalayan region. The Karam Singh episode towards the end of October 1959 (where an Indian patrol had been captured and then allegedly brainwashed), however, galvanized the Indians into action, who now frantically started pushing men and equipment into both Ladakh and NEFA, with little or no thought to the fact that the winter months were only going to compound their problems.

The Western Army Commander at the time was Lieutenant General Pran Thapar and Lieutenant General S. D. Verma commanded the subordinate XV Corps, under whose watch lay the expanse of Zanskar and Ladakh. Verma, like Thimayya and Thorat, was of the school that counselled caution and restraint and adherence to the basic principles of war and was hence a marked man in the eyes of Menon and Kaul.

It was obvious by then that Nehru was making statements in Parliament to placate a hostile Opposition and the few journalists who knew of Ladakh or NEFA. The government’s instructions were at best confused—this was no different from the orders issued by Army HQ through 1960-61, which were perfunctory and vague. The discussions were of ‘limited defence measures to contain Chinese incursions into Indian territory’ giving ‘parsimonious financial experts a chance to hinder, delay and block proposals for reorganizing the Army’. Operational planning was based entirely on available airlift capability, and on the assumption that the Chinese would not react to any Indian move. Numerous small posts with poor military effectiveness were established across a massive front with a